



Horror and the Monstrous-Feminine: An Imaginary Abjection

Barbara Creed

Horror and Abjection

Mother is not herself today.

—Norman Bates, *Psycho*

All human societies have a conception of the monstrous-feminine, of what it is about woman that is shocking, terrifying, horrific, abject. “Probably no male human being is spared the terrifying shock of threatened castration at the sight of the female genitals,” Freud wrote in his paper “Fetishism” in 1927.¹ Joseph Campbell, in his book *Primitive Mythology*, noted that “there is a motif occurring in certain primitive mythologies, as well as in modern surrealist painting and neurotic dream, which is known to folklore as ‘the toothed vagina’—the vagina that castrates. And a counterpart, the other way, is the so-called ‘phallic mother,’ a motif perfectly illustrated in the long fingers and nose of the witch.”² Classical mythology also was populated with gendered monsters, many of which were female. The Medusa, with her “evil eye,” head of writhing serpents, and lolling tongue, was queen of the pantheon of female

monsters; men unfortunate enough to look at her were turned immediately to stone.

It is not by accident that Freud linked the sight of the Medusa to the equally horrifying sight of the mother's genitals, for the concept of the monstrous-feminine, as constructed within and by a patriarchal and phallogentric ideology, is related intimately to the problem of sexual difference and castration. In 1922 he argued that the "Medusa's head takes the place of a representation of the female genitals."³ If we accept Freud's interpretation, we can see that the Perseus myth is mediated by a narrative about the *difference* of female sexuality as a difference which is grounded in monstrousness and which invokes castration anxiety in the male spectator. "The sight of the Medusa's head makes the spectator stiff with terror, turns him to stone."⁴ The irony of this was not lost on Freud, who pointed out that becoming stiff also means having an erection. "Thus in the original situation it offers consolation to the spectator: he is still in possession of a penis, and the stiffening reassures him of the fact."⁵ One wonders if the experience of horror—of viewing the horror film—causes similar alterations in the body of the male spectator. And what of other phrases that apply to both male and female viewers—phrases such as "It scared the shit out of me"; "It made me feel sick"; "It gave me the creeps"? What is the relationship between physical states, bodily wastes (even if metaphorical ones), and the horrific—in particular, the monstrous-feminine?

Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* provides us with a preliminary hypothesis for an analysis of these questions. Although this study is concerned with literature, it nevertheless suggests a way of situating the monstrous-feminine in the horror film in relation to the maternal figure and what Kristeva terms "abjection," that which does not "respect borders, positions, rules," that which "disturbs identity, system, order."⁶ In general terms, Kristeva is attempting to explore the different ways in which abjection, as a source of horror, works within patriarchal societies as a means of separating the human from the non-human and the fully constituted subject from the partially formed subject. Ritual becomes a means by which societies both renew their initial contact with the abject element and then exclude that element.

Through ritual, the demarcation lines between human and nonhuman are drawn up anew and presumably made all the stronger for that process. One of the key figures of abjection is the mother who becomes an abject at that moment when the child rejects her for the father who represents the symbolic order. The problem with Kristeva's theory, particularly for feminists, is that she never makes clear her position on the oppression of women. Her theory moves uneasily between explanation of, and justification for, the formation of human societies based on the subordination of women.

Kristeva grounds her theory of the maternal in the abject, tracing its changing definitions from the period of the pagan or mother-goddess religions to the time of Judaic monotheism and to its culmination in Christianity. She deals with abjection in the following forms: as a rite of defilement in paganism; as a biblical abomination, a taboo, in Judaism; and as self-defilement, an interiorization, in Christianity. Kristeva, however, does not situate abjection solely within a ritual or religious context. She argues that it is “rooted historically (in the history of religions) and subjectively (in the structuration of the subject’s identity), in the cathexis of maternal function—mother, woman, reproduction” (p. 91). Kristeva’s central interest, however, lies with the structuring of subjectivity within and by the processes of abjectivity in which the subject is spoken by the abject through both religious and cultural discourses, that is, through the subject’s position within the practices of the rite as well as within language.

But the question for the analyst-semiologist is to know how far one can analyze ritual impurity. The historian of religion stops soon: the critically impure is that which is based on a natural “loathing.” The anthropologist goes further: there is nothing “loathsome” in itself; the loathsome is that which disobeys classification rules peculiar to the given symbolic system. But as far as I am concerned, I keep asking questions. . . . Are there no subjective structurations that, within the organization of each speaking being, correspond to this or that symbolic-social system and represent, if not stages, at least *types* of subjectivity and society? Types that would be defined, in the last analysis, according to the subject’s position in language . . . ? (p. 92)

A full examination of this theory is outside the scope of this article; I propose to draw mainly on Kristeva’s discussion of abjection in its construction in the human subject in relation to her notions of (a) the “border” and (b) the mother-child relationship. At crucial points, I shall also refer to her writing on the abject in relation to religious discourses. This area cannot be ignored, for what becomes apparent in reading her work is that definitions of the monstrous as constructed in the modern horror text are grounded in ancient religious and historical notions of abjection—particularly in relation to the following religious “abominations”: sexual immorality and perversions; corporeal alteration, decay, and death; human sacrifice; murder; the corpse; bodily wastes; the feminine body; and incest.

The place of the abject is “the place where meaning collapses” (p. 2), the place where “I” am not. The abject threatens life; it must be “radically ex-

cluded” (p. 2) from the place of the living subject, propelled away from the body and deposited on the other side of an imaginary border which separates the self from that which threatens the self. Kristeva quotes Bataille: “Abjection . . . is merely the inability to assume with sufficient strength the imperative act of excluding abject things (and that act establishes the foundations of collective existence)” (p. 56). Although the subject must exclude the abject, it must, nevertheless, be tolerated, for that which threatens to destroy life also helps to define life. Further, the activity of exclusion is necessary to guarantee that the subject take up his or her proper place in relation to the symbolic.

To each ego its object, to each superego its abject. It is not the white expanse or slack boredom of repression, not the translations and transformations of desire that wrench bodies, nights and discourse; rather it is a brutish suffering that “I” puts up with, sublime and devastated, for “I” deposits it to the father’s account (*verse au pere—pere-version*): I endure it, for I imagine such is the desire of the other. . . . On the edge of non-existence and hallucination, of a reality that, if I acknowledge it, annihilates me. There, abject and abjection are my safeguards. The primers of my culture. (p. 2)

The abject can be experienced in various ways, one of which relates to biological bodily functions, the other of which has been inscribed in a symbolic (religious) economy. For instance, Kristeva claims that food loathing is “perhaps the most elementary and archaic form of abjection” (p. 2). Food, however, becomes abject only if it signifies a border “between two distinct entities or territories” (p. 75). Kristeva describes how, for her, the skin on the top of milk, which is offered to her by her father and mother, is a “sign of their desire,” a sign separating her world from their world, a sign which she does not want. “But since the food is not an ‘other’ for ‘me,’ who am only in their desire, I expel *myself*, I spit *myself* out, I abject *myself* within the same motion through which ‘I’ claim to establish *myself*” (p. 3). Dietary prohibitions are, of course, central to Judaism. Kristeva argues that these are directly related to the prohibition of incests; she argues this not just because this position is supported by psychoanalytic discourse and structural anthropology but also because “the biblical text, as it proceeds, comes back, at the intensive moments of its demonstration and expansion, to that mytheme of the archaic relation to the mother” (p. 106).

The ultimate in abjection is the corpse. The body protects itself from bodily wastes such as feces, blood, urine, and pus by ejecting these substances just as it expels food that, for whatever reason, the subject finds loathsome. The

body extricates itself from them and from the place where they fall, so that it might continue to live.

Such wastes drop so that I might live, until, from loss to loss, nothing remains in me and my entire body falls beyond the limit—*cadere*, cadaver. If dung signifies the other side of the border, the place where I am not and which permits me to be, the corpse, the most sickening of wastes, is a border that has encroached upon everything. It is no longer I who expel. “I” is expelled. (pp. 3–4)

Within the biblical context, the corpse is also utterly abject. It signifies one of the most basic forms of pollution—the body without a soul. As a form of waste it represents the opposite of the spiritual, the religious symbolic: “Corpse fanciers, unconscious worshippers of a soulless body, are thus preeminent representatives of inimical religions, identified by their murderous cults. The priceless debt to great mother nature, from which the prohibitions of Yahwistic speech separates us, is concealed in such pagan cults” (p. 109).

In relation to the horror film, it is relevant to note that several of the most popular horrific figures are “bodies without souls” (the vampire), the “living corpse” (the zombie), and the corpse-eater (the ghoul). Here the horror film constructs and confronts us with the fascinating, seductive aspect of abjection. What is also interesting is that such ancient figures of abjection as the vampire, the ghoul, the zombie, and the witch (one of whose many crimes was that she used corpses for her rites of magic) continue to provide some of the most compelling images of horror in the modern cinema. The werewolf, whose body signifies a collapse of the boundaries between human and animal, also belongs to this category.

Abjection also occurs where the individual fails to respect the law and where the individual is a hypocrite, a liar, a traitor: “Any crime, because it draws attention to the fragility of the law, is abject, but premeditated crime, cunning murder, hypocritical revenge are even more so because they heighten the display of such fragility. He who denies morality is not abject; there can be grandeur in amorality. . . . Abjection, on the other hand, is immoral, sinister, scheming, and shady” (p. 4). Thus, abject things are those which highlight the “fragility of the law” and which exist on the other side of the border that separates out the living subject from that which threatens its extinction. But abjection is not something of which the subject can ever feel free—it is always there, beckoning the self to take up its place, the place where meaning collapses. The subject, constructed in and through language, through a desire for meaning, is also spoken by the abject, the place of mean-

inglessness—thus, the subject is constantly beset by abjection which fascinates desire but which must be repelled for fear of self-annihilation. The crucial point is that abjection is always ambiguous. Like Bataille, Kristeva emphasizes the attraction, as well as the horror, of the undifferentiated:

We may call it a border; abjection is above all ambiguity. Because, while releasing a hold, it does not radically cut off the subject from what threatens it—on the contrary, abjection acknowledges it to be in perpetual danger. But also because abjection itself is a composite of judgement and affect, of condemnation and yearning, of signs and drives. Abjection preserves what existed in the archaism of pre-objectal relationship. . . . (pp. 9–10)

To the extent that abjection works on the sociocultural arena, the horror film would appear to be, in at least three ways, an illustration of the work of abjection. First, the horror film abounds in images of abjection, foremost of which is the corpse, whole and mutilated, followed by an array of bodily wastes such as blood, vomit, saliva, sweat, tears, and putrifying flesh. In terms of Kristeva's notion of the border, when we say such-and-such a horror film "made me sick" or "scared the shit out of me,"⁷ we are actually foregrounding that specific horror film as a "work of abjection" or "abjection at work"—in both a literal and metaphoric sense. Viewing the horror film signifies a desire not only for perverse pleasure (confronting sickening, horrific images, being filled with terror/desire for the undifferentiated) but also a desire, having taken pleasure in perversity, to throw up, throw out, eject the object (from the safety of the spectator's seat).

Second, there is, of course, a sense in which the concept of a border is central to the construction of the monstrous in the horror film; that which crosses or threatens to cross the "border" is object. Although the specific nature of the border changes from film to film, the function of the monstrous remains the same: to bring about an encounter between the symbolic order and that which threatens its stability. In some horror films the monstrous is produced at the border between human and inhuman, man and beast (*Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde* [1931, 1941], *Creature from the Black Lagoon* [1954], *King Kong* [1933]); in others the border is between the normal and the supernatural, good and evil (*Carrie* [1976], *The Exorcist* [1973], *The Omen* [1976], *Rosemary's Baby* [1968]); or the monstrous is produced at the border which separates those who take up their proper gender roles from those who do not (*Psycho* [1960], *Dressed to Kill* [1980], *Reflection of Fear* [1971]); or the border

is between normal and abnormal sexual desire (*Cruising* [1980], *The Hunger* [1983], *Cat People* [1942, 1982]).

In relation to the construction of the abject within religious discourses, it is interesting to note that various subgenres of the horror film seem to correspond to religious categories of abjection. For instance, blood as a religious abomination becomes a form of abjection in the “splatter” movie (*The Texas Chainsaw Massacre* [1974]); cannibalism, another religious abomination, is central to the “meat” movie (*Night of the Living Dead* [1968], *The Hills Have Eyes* [1977]); the corpse as abomination becomes the abject of ghoul and zombie movies (*The Evil Dead* [1982]; *Zombie Flesh eaters* [1979]); blood as a taboo object within religion is central to the vampire film (*The Hunger*) as well as the horror film in general (*Bloodsucking Freaks* [a.k.a. *The Incredible Torture Show*, 1976]); human sacrifice as a religious abomination is constructed as the abject of virtually all horror films; and bodily disfigurement as a religious abomination is also central to the slash movie, particularly those in which woman is slashed, the mark a sign of her “difference,” her impurity (*Dressed to Kill*, *Psycho*).

The Abject Mother

The third way in which the horror film illustrates the work of abjection refers to the construction of the maternal figure as abject. Kristeva argues that all individuals experience abjection at the time of their earliest attempts to break away from the mother. She sees the mother-child relation as one marked by conflict: the child struggles to break free but the mother is reluctant to release it. Because of the “instability of the symbolic function” in relation to this most crucial area—“the prohibition placed on the maternal body (as a defense against autoeroticism and incest taboo)” (p. 14)—Kristeva argues that the maternal body becomes a site of conflicting desires. “Here, drives hold sway and constitute a strange space that I shall name, after Plato (*Timeus*, 48–53), a *chora*, a receptacle” (p. 14). The position of the child is rendered even more unstable because, while the mother retains a close hold over the child, it can serve to authenticate her existence—an existence which needs validation because of her problematic relation to the symbolic realm.

It is a violent, clumsy breaking away, with the constant risk of falling back under the sway of a power as securing as it is stifling. The difficulty the mother has in acknowledging (or being acknowledged by) the sym-

bolic realm—in other words, the problems she has with the phallus that her father or husband stands for—is not such as to help the future subject leave the natural mansion. (p. 13)

In the child's attempt to break away, the mother becomes an object; thus, in this context, where the child struggles to become a separate subject, abjection becomes "*a precondition of narcissism*" (p. 13). Once again we can see abjection at work in the horror text where the child struggles to break away from the mother, representative of the archaic maternal figure, in a context in which the father is invariably absent (*Psycho*, *Carrie*, *The Birds* [1963]). In these films, the maternal figure is constructed as the monstrous-feminine. By refusing to relinquish her hold on her child, she prevents it from taking up its proper place in relation to the Symbolic. Partly consumed by the desire to remain locked in a blissful relationship with the mother and partly terrified of separation, the child finds it easy to succumb to the comforting pleasure of the dyadic relationship. Kristeva argues that a whole area of religion has assumed the function of tackling this danger:

This is precisely where we encounter the rituals of defilement and their derivatives, which, based on the feeling of abjection and all converging on the maternal, attempt to symbolize the other threat to the subject: that of being swamped by the dual relationship, thereby risking the loss not of a part (castration) but of the totality of his living being. The function of these religious rituals is to ward off the subject's fear of his very own identity sinking irretrievably into the mother. (p. 64)

How, then, are prohibitions against contact with the mother enacted and enforced? In answering this question, Kristeva links the universal practices of rituals of defilement to the mother. She argues that within the practices of all rituals of defilement, polluting objects fall into two categories: excremental, which threatens identity from the outside, and menstrual, which threatens from within.

Excrement and its equivalent (decay, infection, disease, corpse, etc.) stand for the danger to identity that comes from without: the ego threatened by the non-ego, society threatened by its outside, life by death. Menstrual blood, on the contrary, stands for the danger issuing from within identity (social or sexual); it threatens the relationship between the sexes within a social aggregate and, through internalization, the identity of each sex in the face of sexual difference. (p. 71)

Both categories of polluting objects relate to the mother: the relation of menstrual blood is self-evident; the association of excremental objects with the maternal figure is brought about because of the mother's role in sphincter training. Here Kristeva argues that the subject's first contact with "authority" is with the maternal authority when the child learns, through interaction with the mother, about its body: the shape of the body, the clean and unclean, the proper and improper areas of the body. Kristeva refers to this process as a "primal mapping of the body" that she calls "semiotic." She distinguishes between maternal "authority" and "paternal laws": "Maternal authority is the trustee of that mapping of the self's clean and proper body; it is distinguished from paternal laws within which, with the phallic phase and acquisition of language, the destiny of man will take shape" (p. 72). In her discussion of rituals of defilement in relation to the Indian caste system, Kristeva draws a distinction between the maternal authority and paternal law. She argues that the period of the "mapping of the self's clean and proper body" is characterized by the exercise of "authority without guilt," a time when there is a "fusion between mother and nature." However, the symbolic ushers in a "totally different universe of socially signifying performances where embarrassment, shame, guilt, desire etc. come into play—the order of the phallus." In the Indian context, these two worlds exist harmoniously side by side because of the working of defilement rites. Here Kristeva is referring to the practice of public defecation in India. She quotes V. S. Naipaul, who says that no one ever mentions "in speech or in books, those squatting figures, because, quite simply, no one sees them." Kristeva argues that this split between the world of the mother (a universe without shame) and the world of the father (a universe of shame) would, in other social contexts, produce psychosis; in India it finds a "perfect socialization": "This may be because the setting up of the rite of defilement takes on the function of the hyphen, the virgule, allowing the two universes of *filth* and *prohibition* to brush lightly against each other without necessarily being identified as such, as *object* and as *law*" (p. 74).

Images of blood, vomit, pus, shit, and so forth, are central to our culturally/socially constructed notions of the horrific. They signify a split between two orders: the maternal authority and the law of the father. On the one hand, these images of bodily wastes threaten a subject that is already constituted, in relation to the symbolic, as "whole and proper." Consequently, they fill the subject—both the protagonist in the text and the spectator in the cinema—with disgust and loathing. On the other hand, they also point back to a time when a "fusion between mother and nature" existed; when bodily wastes, while set apart from the body, were not seen as objects of embarrassment and shame. Their presence in the horror film may evoke a response of disgust

from the audience, situated as it is within the symbolic, but at a more archaic level the representation of bodily wastes may evoke pleasure in breaking the taboo of filth—sometimes described as a pleasure in perversity—and a pleasure in returning to that time when the mother-child relationship was marked by an untrammelled pleasure in “playing” with the body and its wastes.

The modern horror film often “plays” with its audience, saturating it with scenes of blood and gore, deliberately pointing to the fragility of the symbolic order in the domain of the body which never ceases to signal the repressed world of the mother. This is particularly evident in *The Exorcist*, where the world of the symbolic, represented by the priest-as-father, and the world of the presymbolic, represented by woman aligned with the devil, clashes head on in scenes where the foulness of woman is signified by her putrid, filthy body covered in blood, urine, excrement, and bile. Significantly, a pubescent girl about to menstruate played the woman who is possessed—in one scene blood from her wounded genitals mingles with menstrual blood to provide one of the film’s key images of horror. In *Carrie*, the film’s most monstrous act occurs when the couple are drenched in pig’s blood, which symbolizes menstrual blood—women are referred to in the film as “pigs,” women “bleed like pigs,” and the pig’s blood runs down Carrie’s body at a moment of intense pleasure, just as her own menstrual blood runs down her legs during a similar pleasurable moment when she enjoys her body in the shower. Here women’s blood and pig’s blood flow together, signifying horror, shame, and humiliation. In this film, however, the mother speaks for the symbolic, identifying with an order that has defined women’s sexuality as the source of all evil and menstruation as the sign of sin. The horror film’s obsession with blood, particularly the bleeding body of woman, where her body is transformed into the “gaping wound,” suggests that castration anxiety is a central concern of the horror film—particularly the slasher subgenre. Woman’s body is slashed and mutilated, not only to signify her own castrated state, but also the possibility of castration for the male. In the guise of a “madman” he enacts on her body the one act he most fears for himself, transforming her entire body into a bleeding wound.

Kristeva’s semiotic posits a preverbal dimension of language that relates to sounds and tone and to direct expression of the drives and physical contact with the maternal figure: “it is dependent upon meaning, but in a way that is not that of *linguistic* signs nor of the *symbolic* order they found” (p. 72). With the subject’s entry into the symbolic, which separates the child from the mother, the maternal figure and the authority she signifies are repressed. Kristeva argues that it is the function of defilement rites, particularly those relating to



The Exorcist (1973): the world of the presymbolic represented by the foul, possessed female body (Linda Blair).

menstrual and excremental objects, to point to the “boundary” between the maternal semiotic authority and the paternal symbolic law:

Through language and within highly hierarchical religious institutions, man hallucinates partial “objects”—witnesses to an archaic differentiation of the body on its way toward ego identity, which is also sexual identity. The *defilement* from which ritual protects us is neither sign nor matter. Within the rite that extracts it from repression and depraved desire, defilement is the translinguistic spoor of the most archaic boundaries of the self’s clean and proper body. In that sense, if it is a jettisoned object, it is so from the mother. . . . By means of the symbolic institution of ritual, that is to say, by means of a system of ritual exclusions, the partial-object consequently becomes *scription*—an inscription of limits,

an emphasis placed not on the (paternal) Law but on (maternal) Authority through the very signifying order. (p. 73)

Kristeva argues that, historically, it has been the function of religion to purify the abject but with the disintegration of these “historical forms” of religion, the work of purification now rests solely with “that catharsis par excellence called art” (p. 17).

In a world in which the Other has collapsed, the aesthetic task—a descent into the foundations of the symbolic construct—amounts to re-tracing the fragile limits of the speaking being, closest to its dawn, to the bottomless “primacy” constituted by primal repression. Through that experience, which is nevertheless managed by the Other, “subject” and “object” push each other away, confront each other, collapse, and start again—inseparable, contaminated, condemned, at the boundary of what is assimilable, thinkable: abject. (p. 18)

This, I would argue, is also the central ideological project of the popular horror film—purification of the abject through a “descent into the foundations of the symbolic construct.” In this way, the horror film brings about a confrontation with the abject (the corpse, bodily wastes, the monstrous-feminine) in order, finally, to eject the abject and redraw the boundaries between the human and nonhuman. As a form of modern defilement rite, the horror film works to separate out the symbolic order from all that threatens its stability, particularly the mother and all that her universe signifies. In Kristeva’s terms, this means separating out the maternal authority from paternal law.

As mentioned earlier, the central problem with Kristeva’s theory is that it can be read in a prescriptive rather than a descriptive sense. This problem is rendered more acute by the fact that, although Kristeva distinguishes between the maternal and paternal figures when she speaks of the subject who is being constituted, she never distinguishes between the child as male or female. Obviously, the female child’s experience of the semiotic *chora* must be different from the male’s experience in relation to the way it is spoken to, handled, and so on. For the mother is already constituted as a gendered subject living within a patriarchal order and thus aware of the differences between the “masculine” and the “feminine” in relation to questions of desire. Thus, the mother might relate to a male child with a more acute sense of pride and pleasure. It is also possible that the child, depending on its gender, might find it more or less difficult to reject the mother for the father. Kristeva does not consider any of these issues. Nor does she distinguish between the

relation of the adult male and female subject to rituals of defilement—for instance, menstruation taboos, where one imagines notions of the gendered subject would be of crucial importance. How, for instance, do women relate to rites of defilement such as menstruation rites, which reflect so negatively on them? How do women within a specific cultural group see themselves in relation to taboos that construct their procreative functions as abject? Is it possible to intervene in the social construction of woman as abject? Or is the subject's relationship to the processes of abjectivity, as they are constructed within subjectivity and language, completely unchangeable? Is the abjection of women a precondition for the continuation of sociality? Kristeva never asks questions of this order. Consequently her theory of abjection could be interpreted as an apology for the establishment of sociality at the cost of women's equality. If, however, we read it as descriptive, as one attempting to explain the origins of patriarchal culture, then it provides us with an extremely useful hypothesis for an investigation of the representation of women in the horror film.⁸

Alien and the Primal Scene

The science fiction horror film *Alien* (1979) is a complex representation of the monstrous-feminine in terms of the maternal figure as perceived within a patriarchal ideology. She is there in the text's scenarios of the primal scene, of birth and death; she is there in her many guises as the treacherous mother, the oral sadistic mother, the mother as primordial abyss; and she is there in the film's images of blood, of the all-devouring vagina, the toothed vagina, the vagina as Pandora's box; and finally she is there in the chameleon figure of the alien, the monster as fetish object of and for the mother. But it is the archaic mother, the reproductive/generative mother, who haunts the mise-en-scène of the film's first section, with its emphasis on different representations of the primal scene.

According to Freud, every child either watches its parents in the act of sexual intercourse or has fantasies about that act—fantasies that relate to the problem of origins. Freud left open the question of the cause of the fantasy but suggested that it may initially be aroused by “an observation of the sexual intercourse of animals.”⁹ In his study of “the Wolf Man,” Freud argued that the child did not initially observe the parents in the act of sexual intercourse but rather witnessed the copulation of animals whose behavior the child then displaced onto the parents. In situations where the child actually witnesses sexual intercourse between its parents, Freud argued that all children arrive at the

same conclusion: “They adopt what may be called a *sadistic view of coition*.”¹⁰ If the child perceives the primal scene as a monstrous act—whether in reality or fantasy—it may fantasize animals or mythical creatures as taking part in the scenario. Possibly the many mythological stories in which humans copulate with animals and other creatures (Europa and Zeus, Leda and the Swan) are reworkings of the primal scene narrative. The Sphinx, with her lion’s body and woman’s face, is an interesting figure in this context. Freud suggested that the Riddle of the Sphinx was probably a distorted version of the great riddle that faces all children—Where do babies come from? An extreme form of the primal fantasy is that of “observing parental intercourse while one is still an unborn baby in the womb.”¹¹

One of the major concerns of the science fiction horror film (*Alien*, *The Thing* [1951, 1982], *Invasion of the Body Snatchers* [1956, 1978], *Altered States* [1980]) is the reworking of the primal scene in relation to the representation of other forms of copulation and procreation. *Alien* presents various representations of the primal scene. Behind each of these lurks the figure of the archaic mother, that is, the image of the mother in her generative function—the mother as the origin of all life. This archaic figure is somewhat different from the mother of the semiotic *chora* posed by Kristeva in that the latter is the pre-Oedipal mother who exists in relation to the family and the symbolic order. The concept of the parthenogenic, archaic mother adds another dimension to the maternal figure and presents us with a new way of understanding how patriarchal ideology works to deny the “difference” of woman in her cinematic representation.

The first birth scene occurs in *Alien* at the beginning, where the camera/ spectator explores the inner space of the mother-ship whose life support system is a computer aptly named “Mother.” This exploratory sequence of the inner body of the Mother culminates with a long tracking shot down one of the corridors which leads to a womblike chamber where the crew of seven are woken up from their protracted sleep by Mother’s voice monitoring a call for help from a nearby planet. The seven astronauts emerge slowly from their sleep pods in what amounts to a rebirthing scene that is marked by a fresh, antiseptic atmosphere. In outer space, birth is a well-controlled, clean, painless affair. There is no blood, trauma, or terror. This scene could be interpreted as a primal fantasy in which the human subject is born fully developed—even copulation is redundant.

The second representation of the primal scene takes place when three of the crew enter the body of the unknown spaceship through a “vaginal” opening: the ship is shaped like a horseshoe, its curved sides like two long legs spread apart at the entrance. They travel along a corridor that seems to



Alien (1979): the vaginal openings of the alien space ship.

be made of a combination of inorganic and organic material—as if the inner space of this ship were alive. Compared to the atmosphere of the *Nostromo*, however, this ship is dark, dank, and mysterious. A ghostly light glimmers, and the sounds of their movements echo throughout the caverns. In the first chamber, the three explorers find a huge alien life form that appears to have been dead for a long time. Its bones are bent outward as if it exploded from the inside. One of the trio, Kane, is lowered down a shaft into the gigantic womblike chamber in which rows of eggs are hatching. Kane approaches one of the eggs; as he touches it with his gloved hand, it opens out, revealing a mass of pulsating flesh. Suddenly the monstrous thing inside leaps up and attaches itself to Kane's helmet, its tail penetrating Kane's mouth in order to fertilize itself inside his stomach. Despite the warnings of Ripley, Kane is taken back on board the *Nostromo* where the alien rapidly completes its gestation processes inside Kane.

This representation of the primal scene recalls Freud's reference to an extreme primal-scene fantasy in which the subject imagines traveling back inside the womb to watch her or his parents having sexual intercourse, perhaps to watch her or his own conception. Here three astronauts explore the gigantic, cavernous, malevolent womb of the mother. Two members of the group

watch the enactment of the primal scene in which Kane is violated in an act of phallic penetration—by the father or phallic mother? Kane himself is guilty of the strongest transgression; he actually peers into the egg/womb in order to investigate its mysteries. In so doing, he becomes a part of the primal scene, taking up the place of the mother, the one who is penetrated, the one who bears the offspring of the union. The primal scene is represented as violent and monstrous (the union is between human and alien), and is mediated by the question of incestuous desire. All restagings of the primal scene raise the question of incest, as the beloved parent (usually the mother) is with a rival. The first birth scene, in which the astronauts emerge from their sleep pods, could be viewed as a representation of incestuous desire par excellence: the father is completely absent; here the mother is sole parent and sole life support.

From this forbidden union, the monstrous creature is born. But man, not woman, is the “mother,” and Kane dies in agony as the alien gnaws its way through his stomach. The birth of the alien from Kane’s stomach plays on what Freud described as a common misunderstanding that many children have about birth: that the mother is somehow impregnated through the mouth—she may eat a special food—and the baby grows in her stomach from which it is also born. Here we have a third version of the primal scene.

A further version of the primal scene—almost a convention of the science fiction film¹²—occurs when smaller crafts or bodies are ejected from the mother ship into outer space, although the ejected body sometimes remains attached to the mother ship by a long lifeline or umbilical cord. This scene is presented in two separate ways: when Kane’s body, wrapped in a white shroud, is ejected from the mother ship; and when the small space capsule, in which Ripley is trying to escape from the alien, is expelled from the underbelly of the mother ship. In the former, the “mother’s” body has become hostile; it contains the alien whose one purpose is to kill and devour all of Mother’s children. In the latter birth scene the living infant is ejected from the malevolent body of the “mother” to avoid destruction; in this scenario, the “mother’s” body explodes at the moment of giving birth.

Although the “mother” as a figure does not appear in these sequences—nor indeed in the entire film—her presence forms a vast backdrop for the enactment of all the events. She is there in the images of birth, the representations of the primal scene, the womblike imagery, the long winding tunnels leading to inner chambers, the rows of hatching eggs, the body of the mother ship, the voice of the life-support system, and the birth of the alien. She is the generative mother, the pre-phallic mother, the being who exists prior to knowledge of the phallus.

In explaining his difficulty in uncovering the role of the mother in the early development of infants, Freud complained of the almost “prehistoric” remoteness of this “Minoan-Mycenaean” stage: “Everything in the sphere of this first attachment to the mother seemed to me so difficult to grasp in analysis—so grey with age and shadowy and almost impossible to revivify—that it was as if it had succumbed to an especially inexorable repression.”¹³ Just as the Oedipus complex tends to hide the pre-Oedipal phase in Freudian theory, the figure of the father, in the Lacanian rewriting of Freud, obscures the mother-child relationship of the imaginary. In contrast to the maternal figure of the Lacanian imaginary, Kristeva posits another dimension to the mother—she is associated with the preverbal or the semiotic and as such tends to disrupt the symbolic order.¹⁴

I think it is possible to open up the mother question still further and posit an even more archaic maternal figure, to go back to mythological narratives of the generative, parthenogenetic mother—that archaic figure who gives birth to all living things. She exists in the mythology of all human cultures as the mother-goddess who alone created the heavens and earth. In China she was known as Nu Kwa, in Mexico as Coatlicue, in Greece as Gaia (literally meaning “earth”), and in Sumer as Nammu. In “Moses and Monotheism,” Freud attempted to account for the historical existence of the great mother-goddesses: “It is likely that the mother-goddesses originated at the time of the curtailment of the matriarchy, as a compensation for the slight upon the mothers. The male deities appear first as sons beside the great mothers and only later clearly assume the features of father-figures. These male gods of polytheism reflect the conditions during the patriarchal age.”¹⁵ Freud proposed that human society developed through stages from patriarchy to matriarchy and finally back to patriarchy. During the first, primitive people lived in small hordes, each one dominated by a jealous, powerful father who possessed all the females of the group. One day the sons, who had been banished to the outskirts of the group, overthrew the father—whose body they devoured—in order to secure his power and to take his women for themselves. Overcome by guilt, they later attempted to revoke the deed by setting up a totem as a substitute for the father and by renouncing the women whom they had liberated. The sons were forced to give up the women, whom they all wanted to possess, in order to preserve the group, which otherwise would have been destroyed as the sons fought among themselves. In “Totem and Taboo,” Freud suggests that here “the germ of the institution of matriarchy” may have originated.¹⁶ Eventually, however, this new form of social organization, constructed upon the taboo against

murder and incest, was replaced by the reestablishment of a patriarchal order. He pointed out that the sons had “thus created out of their filial sense of guilt the two fundamental taboos of totemism, which for that very reason inevitably corresponded to the two repressed wishes of the Oedipus complex.”¹⁷

Freud's account of the origins of patriarchal civilization is generally regarded as mythical. Lévi-Strauss points out that it is “a fair account not of the beginnings of civilization, but of its present state” in that it expresses “in symbolical form an inveterate fantasy”—the desire to murder the father and possess the mother.¹⁸ In her discussion of “Totem and Taboo,” Kristeva argues that a “strange slippage” (p. 56) has taken place in that, although Freud points out that morality is founded on the taboos of murder and incest, his argument concentrates on the first to the virtual exclusion of the latter. Yet, Kristeva argues, the “woman—or mother—image haunts a large part of that book and keeps shaping its background” (p. 57). She poses the question:

Could the sacred be, whatever its variants, a two-sided formation? One aspect founded by murder and the social bond made up of a murderer's guilt-ridden atonement, with all the projective mechanisms and obsessive rituals that accompany it; and another aspect, like a lining, more secret and invisible, non-representable, oriented toward those uncertain spaces of unstable identity, toward the fragility—both threatening and fusional—of the archaic dyad, toward the non-separation of subject/object, on which language has no hold but one woven of fright and repulsion? (pp. 57–58)

From the above, it is clear that the figure of the mother in both the history of human sociality and in the history of the individual subject poses immense problems. Freud attempts to account for the existence of the mother-goddess figure by posing a matriarchal period in historical times while admitting that everything to do with the “first attachment to the mother” is deeply repressed—“grey with age and shadowy and almost impossible to revivify.” Nowhere does he attempt to specify the nature of this matriarchal period and its implications for his own psychoanalytical theory, specifically his theory of the Oedipus complex, which, as Lacan points out, “can only appear in a patriarchal form in the institution of the family.”¹⁹ Kristeva criticizes Freud for failing to deal adequately with incest and the mother questions while using the same mystifying language to refer to the mother; the other aspect of the sacred is “like a lining,” “secret and invisible,” “non-representable.” In his rereading of Freud, Lacan mystifies the figure of woman even further: “the woman is not-all, there is always something with her which eludes dis-

course.”²⁰ Further, all three writers conflate the archaic mother with the mother of the dyadic and triadic relationship. They refer to her as a “shadowy” figure (Freud); as “non-representable” (Kristeva); as the “abyss of the female organ from which all life comes forth” (Lacan),²¹ then make no clear attempt to distinguish this aspect of the maternal imago from the protective/suffocating mother of the pre-Oedipal or the mother as object of sexual jealousy and desire as she is represented in the Oedipal configuration.

The maternal figure constructed within and by the writings of Freud, Lacan, and Kristeva is inevitably the mother of the dyadic or triadic relationship, although the latter figure is more prominent. Even when she is represented as the mother of the imaginary, of the dyadic relationship, she is still constructed as the pre-Oedipal mother—that is, as a figure about to “take up a place” in the symbolic, as a figure always in relation to the father, the representative of the phallus. Without her “lack,” he cannot signify its opposite—lack of a lack or presence. But if we posit a more archaic dimension to the mother—the mother as originating womb—we can at least begin to talk about the maternal figure as *outside* the patriarchal family constellation. In this context, the mother-goddess narratives can be read as primal-scene narratives in which the mother is the sole parent. She is also the subject, not the object, of narrativity.

For instance, in the Spider Woman myth of the North American Indians, there was only the Spider Woman, who spun the universe into existence and then created two daughters from whom all life flowed. She is also the Thought Woman or Wise Woman who knows the secrets of the universe. Within the Oedipus narrative, however, she becomes the Sphinx, who also knows the answers to the secret life, but here her situation has been changed. She is no longer the subject of the narrative; she has become the object of the narrative of the male hero. After he has solved her riddle, she will destroy herself. The Sphinx is an ambiguous figure; she knows the secret of life and is thereby linked to the mother-goddess, but her name, which is derived from “sphincter,” suggests she is the mother of toilet training, the pre-Oedipal mother who must be repudiated by the son so that he can take up his proper place in the symbolic. It is interesting that Oedipus has always been seen to have committed two horrific crimes: patricide and incest. But his encounter with the Sphinx, which leads to her death, suggests he is also responsible for another horrific crime—that of matricide. For the Sphinx, like the Medusa, is a mother-goddess figure; they are both variants of the same mythological mother who gave birth to all life. Lévi-Strauss has argued that a major issue in the Oedipus myth is the problem of whether man is born from woman. This myth is also central to *Alien*: “Although the problem obviously cannot

be solved, the Oedipus myth provides a kind of logical tool which relates the original problem—born from one or born from two?—to the derivative problem: born from different or born from same?”²²

The Medusa, whose head signifies, according to Freud, the female genitals in their terrifying aspect, also represents the procreative function of woman. The blood that flows from her severed head gives birth to Pegasus and Chrysaor. Although Neptune is supposed to be the father, the nature of the birth once again suggests the parthenogenetic mother. Teresa de Lauretis argues that “to say that narrative is the production of Oedipus is to say that each reader—male or female—is constrained and defined within the two positions of a sexual difference thus conceived: male-hero-human, on the side of the subject; and female-obstacle-boundary-space, on the other.”²³ If we apply her definition to narratives that deal specifically with the archaic mother—such as the Oedipus and Perseus myths—we can see that the “obstacle” relates specifically to the question of origins and is an attempt to repudiate the idea of woman as the source of life, woman as sole parent, woman as archaic mother.

Roger Dadoun, also referring to this archaic maternal figure, describes her as

. . . a maternal thing situated on this side of good and evil, on this side of all organized form, on this side of all events—a totalizing, oceanic mother, a “mysterious and profound unity,” arousing in the subject the anguish of fusion and of dissolution; the mother prior to the uncovering of the essential *béance* [gap], of the *pas-de-phallus*, the mother who is pure fantasm, in the sense that she is posed as an omnipresent and all-powerful totality, an absolute being, only in the intuition—she does not have a phallus—which deposes her²⁴

Dadoun places emphasis on her “totalizing, oceanic” presence. I would stress her archaism in relation to her generative powers—the mother who gives birth all by herself, the original parent, the godhead of all fertility, and the origin of procreation. What is most interesting about the mythological figure of woman as the source of all life (a role taken over by the male god of monotheistic religions) is that, within patriarchal signifying practices, particularly the horror film, she is reconstructed and represented as a *negative* figure, one associated with the dread of the generative mother seen only as the abyss, the monstrous vagina, the origin of all life threatening to reabsorb what it once birthed. Kristeva also represents her in this negative light: “Fear of the uncontrollable generative mother repels me from the body; I give up

cannibalism because abjection (of the mother) leads me toward respect for the body of the other, my fellow man, my brother” (pp. 78–79).

In this context it is interesting to note that Freud linked the womb to the *unheimlich*, the uncanny:

It often happens that neurotic men declare that they feel that there is something uncanny about the female genital organs. This *unheimlich* place, however, is the entrance to the former *Heim* [home] of all human beings, to the place where each one of us lived once upon a time and in the beginning. There is a joke saying that “Love is home-sickness”; and whenever a man dreams of a place or a country and says to himself, while he is still dreaming: “this place is familiar to me, I’ve been here before,” we may interpret the place as being his mother’s genitals or her body.²⁵

Freud also supported, and elaborated upon, Schelling’s definition of the uncanny as “something which ought to have remained hidden but has come to light.”²⁶ In horror films such as *Alien*, we are given a representation of the female genitals and the womb as uncanny—horrific objects of dread and fascination. Unlike the mythological mother narratives, here the archaic mother, like the Sphinx and the Medusa, is seen only in a negative light. But the central characteristic of the archaic mother is her total dedication to the generative, procreative principle. She is outside morality and the law. Ash’s eulogy to the alien is a description of this mother: “I admire its purity; a survivor unclouded by conscience, remorse or delusions of morality.”

Clearly, it is difficult to separate out completely the figure of the archaic mother, as defined above, from other aspects of the maternal figure—the maternal authority of Kristeva’s semiotic, the mother of Lacan’s imaginary, the phallic woman, the castrated woman. While the different figures signify quite separate things about the monstrous-feminine, as constructed in the horror film, each one is also only part of the whole—a different aspect of the maternal figure. At times the horrific nature of the monstrous-feminine is totally dependent on the merging together of all aspects of the maternal figure into one—the horrifying image of woman as archaic mother, phallic woman, and castrated body represented as a single figure within the horror film. However, the archaic mother is clearly present in two distinct ways in the horror film.

First, the archaic mother—constructed as a negative force—is represented in her phantasmagoric aspects in many horror texts, particularly the science fiction horror film. We see her as the gaping, cannibalistic bird’s mouth in

The Giant Claw (1957); the terrifying spider of *The Incredible Shrinking Man* (1957); the toothed vagina/womb of *Jaws* (1975); and the fleshy, pulsating womb of *The Thing* and *Poltergeist* (1982). What is common to all of these images of horror is the voracious maw, the mysterious black hole that signifies female genitalia as a monstrous sign threatening to give birth to equally horrific offspring as well as threatening to incorporate everything in its path. This is the generative archaic mother, constructed within patriarchal ideology as the primeval “black hole.” This, of course, is also the hole that is opened up by the absence of the penis, the horrifying sight of the mother’s genitals—proof that castration can occur.

However, in the texts cited above, the emphasis is not on castration; rather it is the gestating, all-devouring womb of the archaic mother that generates the horror. Nor are these images of the womb constructed in relation to the penis of the father. Unlike the female genitalia, the womb cannot be constructed as a “lack” in relation to the penis. The womb is not the site of castration anxiety. Rather, the womb signifies “fullness” or “emptiness” but always it is its *own point of reference*. This is why we need to posit a more archaic dimension to the mother. For the concept of the archaic mother allows for a notion of the feminine that does not depend for its definition on a concept of the masculine. The term “archaic mother” signifies woman as sexual difference. In contrast, the maternal figure of the pre-Oedipal is always represented in relation to the penis—the phallic mother who later becomes the castrated mother. Significantly, there is an attempt in *Alien* to appropriate the procreative function of the mother, to represent a man giving birth, to deny the mother as signifier of sexual difference—but here birth can exist only as the other face of death.

Second, the archaic mother is present in all horror films as the blackness of extinction—death. The desires and fears invoked by the image of the archaic mother, as a force that threatens to reincorporate what it once gave birth to, are always there in the horror text—all-pervasive, all-encompassing—because of the constant presence of death. The desire to return to the original oneness of things, to return to the mother/womb, is primarily a desire for non-differentiation. If, as Georges Bataille argues, life signifies discontinuity and separateness, and death signifies continuity and nondifferentiation,²⁷ then the desire for and attraction of death suggests also a desire to return to the state of original oneness with the mother. As this desire to merge occurs after differentiation—that is, after the subject has developed as separate, autonomous self—then it is experienced as a form of psychic death. In this sense, the confrontation with death, as represented in the horror film, gives rise to a terror of self-disintegration, of losing one’s self or ego—often represented cinemat-

ically by a screen that becomes black, signifying the obliteration of self, the self of the protagonist in the film and the spectator in the cinema. This has important consequences for the positioning of the spectator in the cinema.

One of the most interesting structures operating in the screen-spectator relationship relates to the sight/site of the monstrous within the horror text. In contrast to the conventional viewing structures working within other variants of the classic text, the horror film does not constantly work to suture the spectator into the viewing processes. Instead, an unusual phenomenon arises whereby the suturing processes are momentarily undone while the horrific image on the screen challenges the viewer to run the risk of continuing to look. Here I refer to those moments in the horror film when the spectator, unable to stand the images of horror unfolding, is forced to look away, to not-look, to look anywhere but at the screen. Strategies of identification are temporarily broken, as the spectator is constructed in the place of horror, the place where the sight/site can no longer be endured, the place where pleasure in looking is transformed into pain and the spectator is punished for his or her voyeuristic desires. Perhaps this should be referred to as a *fifth* look operating alongside the other “looks” that have been theorized in relation to the screen-spectator relationship.²⁸

Confronted by the sight of the monstrous, the viewing subject is put into crisis. Boundaries, designed to keep the abject at bay, threaten to disintegrate, collapse. According to Lacan, the self is constituted in a process which he called the “mirror phase,” in which the child perceives its own body as a unified whole in an image it receives from outside itself. Thus, the concept of identity is a structure that depends on identification with another. Identity is an imaginary construct, formed in a state of alienation, grounded in misrecognition. Because the self is constructed on an illusion, Lacan argues that it is always in danger of regressing:

Here we see the ego, in its essential resistance to the elusive process of Becoming, to the variations of Desire. This illusion of unity, in which a human being is always looking forward to self-mastery, entails a constant danger of sliding back again into the chaos from which he started; it hangs over the abyss of a dizzy Assent in which one can perhaps see the very essence of Anxiety.²⁹

The horror film puts the viewing subject's sense of a unified self into crisis, specifically in those moments when the image on the screen becomes too threatening or horrific to watch, when the abject threatens to draw the viewing subject to the place “where meaning collapses,” the place of death. By

not-looking, the spectator is able momentarily to withdraw identification from the image on the screen in order to reconstruct the boundary between self and screen and reconstitute the self that is threatened with disintegration. This process of reconstitution of the self is reaffirmed by the conventional ending of the horror narrative in which the monster is usually “named” and destroyed.³⁰

Fear of losing oneself and one’s boundaries is made more acute in a society which values boundaries over continuity and separateness over sameness. Given that death is represented in the horror film as a threat to the self’s boundaries, symbolized by the threat of the monster, death images are most likely to cause the spectator to look away, to not-look. Because the archaic mother is closely associated with death in its negative aspects, her presence is marked negatively within the project of the horror film. Both signify a monstrous obliteration of the self and both are linked to the demonic. Again Kristeva presents a negative image of the maternal figure in her relationship to death: “What is the demoniacal—an inescapable, repulsive, and yet nurtured abomination? The fantasy of an archaic force, on the near side of separation, unconscious, tempting us to the point of losing our differences, our speech, our life; to the point of aphasia, decay, opprobrium, and death?” (p. 107).

Alien collapses the image of the threatening archaic mother, signifying woman as “difference,” into the more recognized figure of the pre-Oedipal mother.³¹ This occurs in relation to two images of the monstrous-feminine: the oral-sadistic mother and the phallic mother. Kane’s transgressive disturbance of the egg/womb initiates a transformation of its latent aggressivity into an active, phallic enemy. The horror then played out can be read in relation to Kristeva’s concept of the semiotic *chora*. As discussed earlier, Kristeva argues that the maternal body becomes the site of conflicting desires (the semiotic *chora*). These desires are constantly staged and restaged in the workings of the horror narrative where the subject is left alone, usually in a strange, hostile place, and forced to confront an unnameable terror, the monster. The monster represents both the subject’s fears of being alone, of being separate from the mother, and the threat of annihilation—often through reincorporation. As oral-sadistic mother, the monster threatens to reabsorb the child she once nurtured. Thus, the monster, like the abject, is ambiguous; it both repels and attracts.

In *Alien*, each of the crew members comes face to face with the alien in a scene whose mise-en-scène is coded to suggest a monstrous, malevolent maternal figure. They watch with fascinated horror as the baby alien gnaws its way through Kane’s stomach; Dallas, the captain, encounters the alien after he

has crawled along the ship's enclosed, womblike air ducts; and the other three members are cannibalized in a frenzy of blood in scenes that emphasize the alien's huge razor-sharp teeth, signifying the monstrous oral-sadistic mother. Apart from the scene of Kane's death, all the death sequences occur in dimly lit, enclosed, threatening spaces reminiscent of the giant hatchery where Kane first encounters the pulsating egg. In these death sequences the terror of being abandoned is matched only by the fear of reincorporation. This scenario, which enacts the conflicting desires at play in the semiotic *chora*, is staged within the body of the mother-ship, the vessel that the space travelers initially trust, until Mother herself is revealed as a treacherous figure programmed to sacrifice the lives of the crew in the interests of the company.

The other face of the monstrous-feminine in *Alien* is the phallic mother. Freud argued that the male child could either accept the threat of castration, thus ending the Oedipus complex, or disavow it. The latter response requires him to mitigate his horror at the sight of the mother's genitals—proof that castration can occur—with a fetish object that substitutes for her missing penis. For him, she is still the phallic mother, the penis-woman. In “Medusa's Head” Freud argued that the head with its hair of writhing snakes represents the terrifying genitals of the mother, but that this head also functions as a fetish object: “The hair upon the Medusa's head is frequently represented in works of art in the form of snakes, and these once again are derived from the castration complex. It is a remarkable fact that, however frightening they may be in themselves, they nevertheless serve actually as a mitigation of horror, for they replace the penis, the absence of which is the cause of horror.”³² Freud noted that a display of the female genitals makes a woman “unapproachable and repels all sexual desires.” He refers to the section in Rabelais which relates “how the Devil took flight when the woman showed him her vulva.”³³ Perseus' solution is to look only at a reflection, a mirror image of her genitals. As with patriarchal ideology, his shield reflects an “altered” representation, a vision robbed of its threatening aspects. The full difference of the mother is denied; she is constructed as other, displayed before the gaze of the conquering male hero, then destroyed.³⁴ The price paid is the destruction of sexual heterogeneity and repression of the maternal signifier. The fetishization of the mother's genitals could occur in those texts where the maternal figure is represented in her phantasmagoric aspects as the gaping, voracious vagina/womb. Do aspects of these images work to mitigate the horror by offering a substitute for the penis?

Roger Dadoun argues very convincingly that the Dracula variant of the vampire movie is “an illustration of the work of the fetish function”:³⁵

. . . against the primitive identification with the mother, a phallus; against the anguish of psychotic break-down, sexuality; against spatio-temporal disorganization, a ritual—and this is what is fabricated, we could say, on the positive slopes of fetishism, a sexualized phallic object, it is as rigid and impressive as it is fragile and threatened, where we will perhaps have the pleasure of recognizing one of the familiar figures of horror film, Count Dracula.³⁶

Dadoun argues that the archaic mother exists as a “non-presence . . . signifying an extremely archaic mode of presence.”³⁷ Signs of the archaic mother in the Dracula film are the small, enclosed village; the pathway through the forest that leads like an umbilical cord to the castle; the central place of enclosure with its winding stairways, spiderwebs, dark vaults, worm-eaten staircases, dust, and damp earth—“all elements which come back to the *imago* of the bad archaic mother.”³⁸ At the center of this, Dracula himself materializes. With his black cape, pointed teeth, rigid body—carried “like an erect phallus”—piercing eyes, and “penetrating look,”³⁹ he is the fetish form, “a substitute of the maternal phallus.”⁴⁰

It is clear, nevertheless, since the threat comes from the absent maternal phallus, that the principal defense is sex. The vampire, markedly fascinated by the maternal *pas-de-phallus* and identifying himself with the archaic mother for lack of having a phallus, becomes phallus; he transfers a default of *having* to the plan of an illusory *being*.⁴¹

As he emerges in Dadoun’s argument, the Dracula figure is very much acting on behalf of the mother—he desires to be the phallus for the mother. When he is finally penetrated by the stake, his heart is “revealed as hollow, a gash, or a gaping wound—it is castration made flesh, blood and *béance*. . . .”⁴² However, it is possible that we could theorize fetishism differently by asking: For whom is the fetish-object a fetish? The male or female subject? In general, the fetishist is usually assumed to be male, although Freud did allow that female fetishism was a possibility.⁴³ The notion of female fetishism is much neglected, although it is present in various patriarchal discourses.

Mary Kelly argues that “it would be a mistake to confine women to the realm of repression, excluding the possibility, for example, of female fetishism”:

When Freud describes castration fears for the woman, this imaginary scenario takes the form of losing her loved objects, especially her chil-



Winding staircases, spiderwebs, and darkness signify the archaic mother in *Dracula* (1931).

dren; the child is going to grow up, leave her, reject her, perhaps die. In order to delay, disavow that separation she has already in a way acknowledged, the woman tends to fetishise the child: by dressing him up, by continuing to feed him no matter how old he gets, or simply by having another “little one.”⁴⁴

In *The Interpretation of Dreams*, Freud discusses the way in which the doubling of a penis symbol indicates an attempt to stave off castration anxieties.⁴⁵ Juliet Mitchell refers to doubling as a sign of a female castration complex: “We can see the significance of this for women, as dreams of repeated number of children—‘little ones’—are given the same import.”⁴⁶ In this context, female fetishism represents an attempt by the female subject to continue to “have” the phallus, to take up a “positive” place in relation to the symbolic.

Female fetishism is clearly represented within many horror texts—as instances of patriarchal signifying practices—but only in relation to male fears and anxieties about women and the question What do women want? (*The Birds*, *Cat People*, *Alien*, *The Thing*). Women as yet do not speak their own “fetishistic” desires within the popular cinema—if, indeed, women have such

desires. The notion of female fetishism is represented in *Alien* in the figure of the monster. The creature is the mother's phallus, attributed to the maternal figure by a phallogentric ideology terrified at the thought that women might desire to have the phallus. The monster as fetish object is not there to meet the desires of the male fetishist, but rather to signify the monstrousness of woman's desire to have the phallus.

In *Alien* the monstrous creature is constructed as the phallus of the negative mother. The image of the archaic mother—threatening because it signifies woman as difference rather than constructed as opposition—is, once again, collapsed into the figure of the pre-Oedipal mother. By relocating the figure of woman within an Oedipal scenario, her image can be recuperated and controlled. The womb, even if represented negatively, is a greater threat than the mother's phallus. As phallic mother, woman is again represented as monstrous. What is horrific is her desire to cling to her offspring in order to continue to “have the phallus.” Her monstrous desire is concretized in the figure of the alien, the creature whose deadly mission is represented as the same as that of the archaic mother—to reincorporate and destroy all life.

If we consider *Alien* in the light of a theory of female fetishism, then the chameleon nature of the alien begins to make sense. Its changing appearance represents a form of doubling or multiplication of the phallus, pointing to the mother's desire to stave off her castration. The alien is the mother's phallus, a fact made perfectly clear in the birth scene when the infant alien rises from Kane's stomach and holds itself erect, glaring angrily around the room, before screeching off into the depths of the ship. But the alien is more than a phallus; it is also coded as a toothed vagina, the monstrous-feminine as the cannibalistic mother. A large part of the ideological project of *Alien* is the representation of the maternal fetish object as an “alien” or foreign shape. This is why the body of the heroine becomes so important at the end of the film.

Much has been written about the final scene, in which Ripley (Sigourney Weaver) undresses before the camera, on the grounds that its voyeurism undermines her role as successful heroine. A great deal has also been written about the cat. Why does she rescue the cat and thereby risk her life, and the lives of Parker and Lambert, when she has previously been so careful about quarantine regulations? Again, satisfactory answers to these questions are provided by a phallogentric concept of female fetishism. Compared to the horrific sight of the alien as fetish object of the monstrous-feminine, Ripley's body is pleasurable and reassuring to look at. She signifies the “acceptable” form and shape of woman. In a sense the monstrousness of woman, represented by Mother as betrayer (the computer/life-support system) and Mother as the uncontrollable, generative, cannibalistic mother (the alien), is controlled

through the display of woman as reassuring and pleasurable sign. The image of the cat functions in the same way; it signifies an acceptable, and in this context, a reassuring fetish object for the “normal” woman.⁴⁷ Thus, Ripley holds the cat to her, stroking it as if it were her “baby,” her “little one.” Finally, Ripley enters her sleep pod, assuming a virginal repose. The nightmare is over and we are returned to the opening sequence of the film where birth was a pristine affair. The final sequence works, not only to dispose of the alien, but also to repress the nightmare image of the monstrous-feminine, constructed as a sign of abjection within the text’s patriarchal discourses.

Kristeva’s theory of abjection, if viewed as description rather than prescription, provides a productive hypothesis for an analysis of the monstrous-feminine in the horror film.⁴⁸ If we posit a more archaic dimension to the mother, we can see how this figure, as well as Kristeva’s maternal authority of the semiotic, are both constructed as figures of abjection within the signifying practices of the horror film. We can see its ideological project as an attempt to shore up the symbolic order by constructing the feminine as an imaginary other that must be repressed and controlled in order to secure and protect the social order. Thus, the horror film stages and restages a constant repudiation of the maternal figure.

But the feminine is not a monstrous sign *per se*; rather, it is constructed as such within a patriarchal discourse that reveals a great deal about male desires and fears but tells us nothing about feminine desire in relation to the horrific. When Norman Bates remarked to Marion Crane in *Psycho* that “Mother is not herself today,” he was dead right. Mother wasn’t herself. She was someone else—her son Norman.

Notes

1. Sigmund Freud, “Fetishism,” in *On Sexuality*, Pelican Freud Library, vol. 7 (1977; reprint, Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1981), p. 354.

2. Joseph Campbell, *The Masks of God: Primitive Mythology* (New York: Penguin, 1969), p. 73.

3. Sigmund Freud, “Medusa’s Head,” in *The Standard Edition of the Complete Works of Sigmund Freud*, ed. and trans. James Strachey (London: Hogarth Press, 1964), 18: 273–274.

4. *Ibid.*, p. 273.

5. *Ibid.*

6. Julia Kristeva, *Powers of Horror: An Essay on Abjection* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1982), p. 4. Subsequent references are cited parenthetically in the text.

7. For a discussion of the way in which the modern horror film works upon its audience, see Philip Brophy, "Horrority—the Textuality of Contemporary Horror Films," *Screen* 27, no. 1 (January–February 1986): 2–13.
8. For a critique of *Powers of Horror*, see Jennifer Stone, "The Horrors of Power: A Critique of Kristeva," in *The Politics of Theory*, ed. F. Barker et. al. (Colchester: University of Essex, 1983), pp. 38–48.
9. Sigmund Freud, "From the History of an Infantile Neurosis," in *Case Histories II*, Pelican Freud Library, vol. 9 (1979; reprint, Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1981), p. 294.
10. Sigmund Freud, "On the Sexual Theories of Children," in *On Sexuality*, Pelican Freud Library, vol. 7 (1977; reprint, Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1981), p. 198.
11. Sigmund Freud, "The Paths to the Formation of Symptoms," in *Introductory Lectures on Psychoanalysis*, Pelican Freud Library, vol. 1 (1973; reprint, Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1981), p. 417.
12. Daniel Dervin argues that this structure does deserve the status of a convention. For a detailed discussion of the primal-scene fantasy in various film genres, see his "Primal Conditions and Conventions: The Genres of Comedy and Science Fiction," *Film/ Psychology Review* 4, no. 1 (Winter–Spring 1980): 115–147.
13. Sigmund Freud, "Female Sexuality," in *On Sexuality*, Pelican Freud Library, vol. 7 (1977; reprint, Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1981) p. 373.
14. For a discussion of the relation between the "semiotic" and the Lacanian "imaginary," see Jane Gallop, *The Daughter's Seduction: Feminism and Psychoanalysis* (Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell University Press, 1983), pp. 124–125.
15. Sigmund Freud, "Moses and Monotheism," in *Standard Edition*, 23: 83.
16. Sigmund Freud, "Totem and Taboo," in *The Origins of Religion*, Pelican Freud Library, vol. 13 (Harmondsworth, Penguin, 1985), p. 206.
17. *Ibid.*, p. 205.
18. Quoted in Georges Bataille, *Death and Sensuality: A Study of Eroticism and the Taboo* (New York: Walker and Co., 1962), p. 200.
19. Quoted in Anthony Wilden, ed. and trans., *The Language of Self* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1970), p. 126.
20. Quoted in Stephen Heath, "Difference," *Screen* 19, no. 3 (Autumn 1978): 59.
21. Quoted in *ibid.*, p. 54.
22. Claude Lévi-Strauss, *Structural Anthropology*, trans. C. Jacobson and B. G. Schoepf (New York: Doubleday, 1976), p. 212.
23. Teresa de Lauretis, *Alice Doesn't: Feminism, Semiotics, Cinema* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1984), p. 121.
24. Roger Dadoun, "Fetishism in the Horror Film," *Enlentic* 1, no. 2 (1977): 55–56.
25. Sigmund Freud, "The Uncanny," in *Standard Edition*, 17: 245.
26. *Ibid.*, p. 225.
27. Bataille, *Death and Sensuality*.
28. For a discussion of cinema and the structures of the "look," see Paul Willemen, "Letter to John," *Screen* 21, no. 2 (Summer 1980): 53–66.
29. Jacques Lacan, "Some Reflections on the Ego," *International Journal of Psychoanalysis* 34 (1953): 15.

30. For a discussion of the relationship between the female spectator, structures of looking, and the horror film, see Linda Williams, "When the Woman Looks," in this volume.

31. Dadoun refers to a similar process when he speaks of the displacement of the large "omnipresent mother" into the small "occulted mother." "Fetishism in the Horror Film," p. 55.

32. Sigmund Freud, "Medusa's Head," p. 105.

33. Ibid., p. 106.

34. For a fascinating discussion of the place of woman as monster in the Oedipal narrative, see de Lauretis, *Alice Doesn't*, chap. 5.

35. Dadoun, "Fetishism in the Horror Film," p. 40.

36. Ibid., p. 42.

37. Ibid., p. 53.

38. Ibid., p. 64.

39. Ibid., p. 57.

40. Ibid., p. 56.

41. Ibid., pp. 59–60.

42. Ibid., p. 60.

43. Sigmund Freud, "An Outline of Psychoanalysis," *Standard Edition*, 23: 202: "This abnormality, which may be counted as one of the perversions, is, as is well known, based on the patient (who is *almost always* male) not recognizing the fact that females have no penis" (my emphasis).

44. Mary Kelly, "Woman-Desire-Image," *Desire* (London: Institute of Contemporary Arts, 1984), p. 31.

45. Sigmund Freud, *The Interpretation of Dreams*, Pelican Freud Library, vol. 4 (1976; reprint, Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1982).

46. Juliet Mitchell, *Psychoanalysis and Feminism* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1974), p. 84.

47. The double bird images of Hitchcock's *The Birds* (1963) function in the same way: the love birds signify an "acceptable" fetish, the death birds a fetish of the monstrous woman.

48. For an analysis of the horror film as a "return of the repressed," see Robin Wood, "Return of the Repressed," *Film Comment* 14, no. 4 (July–August 1978): 25–32; and "Neglected Nightmares," *Film Comment* 16, no. 2 (March–April 1980): 24–32.